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Lifeblood of the Party: Motivations for Political Donations in Canada

Holly Ann Garnett ^a, Scott Pruysers ^b, Lisa Young ^c and William P. Cross^d

^aDepartment of Political Science and Economics, Royal Military College of Canada, Kingston, Ontario, Canada; ^bDepartment of Political Science, Dalhousie University, Halifax, Nova Scotia, Canada; ^cDepartment of Political Science, University of Calgary, Calgary, Alberta, Canada; ^dDepartment of Political Science, Carleton University, Ottawa, Ontario, Canada

ABSTRACT

Monetary donations from individuals have become the lifeblood of electoral and partisan politics in Canada, yet we know remarkably little about who these donors are, what motivates them to give, and whether their interactions are primarily with national or local party organizations. This article reports findings from a survey of donors to federal-level political parties in Canada. Our analysis identifies two distinct sets of motivations for donating to parties and candidates: political and transactional. We find that donors are more likely to report stronger political motivations than transactional ones. In general, donors expressing high political motivations tended to be older and less wealthy, but we also note that the strength of the political motivation does not relate to specific donor behaviors.

KEYWORDS

Campaign finance; Canada; elections; political parties; donations

Introduction

The only legal sources of income for Canadian political parties and candidates are publicly funded election expense reimbursements and contributions from individual donors. Those individual contributions must be relatively small, as the legal limit is under \$2,000 annually.¹ Without income from individual donors, national parties would find it impossible to hire staff, conduct polling, or advertise during elections. Local candidates, and the local party organizations that support them, would be similarly hindered. Since contributions from corporations and unions were prohibited in changes to the *Canada Elections Act* adopted in 2003, individual contributors have become an important component of the partisan ecosystem in federal politics in Canada.

Because of substantial barriers to studying this group, relatively little is known about who these donors are, and why and how they give. This article addresses this issue. Having conducted a novel survey of donors to federal political parties, we are able to provide insight into the motivations of this small but essential group. Our exploratory study finds two general categories of motivation for donors: political motivations reflect generalized support for the party and transactional motivations reflect the donor's self-

interest. Most of the donors in our study score higher on measures of political motivation than transactional. We also find that politically motivated donors are more likely to be older and affluent. Political motivation is associated with larger donations. In essence, these individuals are inclined to use their personal resources to influence the outcomes of elections (however unlikely) to conform more closely to their political views. Transactional donors, by contrast, are more likely to be younger and female, and to donate at the local, not national level. They are more likely to contribute to the Liberal and Conservative parties. This speaks to the role of local party associations as a site for individuals to establish themselves within their community, offering a venue to be “seen” as part of a network that extends from the party organization. These findings contribute to our understanding of contemporary political parties in Canada.

The categories of “party member” and “donor” overlap but are not synonymous. Party leaders at both the local and national level are acutely aware of the importance of donors to the party’s ability to contest elections. At the local level, there is a premium on hosting events that give transactional donors an opportunity to signal their interest and support. At the national level, appeals to donors speak to their political motivations to help the party defeat its rivals and their support for the leader.

These findings also speak to the broad approaches to the regulation of political finance. The Canadian election finance regime is predicated on the idea that individual donors giving relatively small amounts is desirable. In this view, donors do not expect a *quid pro quo*, but rather seek to advance their career by being seen to be supporting the party. The politically motivated donors generally express positive motivations, seeking to further the interests of the party and leader with which they agree. Of course, donors are not reflective of the general population in terms of their political orientation, social class, or other demographic characteristics, as such, their desire to influence the direction of electoral democracy does serve to reinforce various biases existing within the political sphere.

Party Donors and Party Members

The extra-parliamentary organization of Canadian political parties is comprised of party members, individuals who have paid a small fee to formally affiliate themselves with the party. Membership has privileges, most notably the ability to vote in intra-party contests selecting candidates and leaders. Party membership in Canada is relatively rare: estimates suggest that roughly 1–2% of eligible voters are party members (Cross 2015). Recent developments have also seen parties, notably the Liberals, move away from a traditional dues-paying membership model to create a broader and more encompassing “supporter” category.²

Donors are those individuals who have given a monetary contribution to the party (national or local), one of its candidates, or one of its leadership contestants. Using administrative data from 2015 (an election year), Tolley, Besco, and Sevi (2020) estimate that *at most* 2.6% of eligible voters were donors, and observe that the figure is likely lower, as they are assuming that each donation comes from a different donor, an assumption that is almost certainly not correct.

Although there is significant overlap between the two groups (See Figure 1), donors and political party members are not synonymous. Cross and Young (2004), for example,

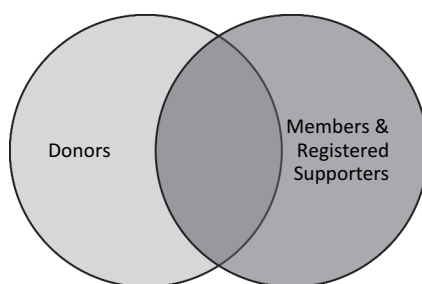


Figure 1. Overlap between party donors and members. Note: Donors are not necessarily members or registered supporters of the party. Likewise, not all members and registered supports necessarily donate.

found that 89 percent of party members reported making donations. More recently, Cross, Pruyzers, and Currie-Wood (2022) report that just 67% of party members report making a financial contribution to their party. In our survey of donors, less than one-third of donors reported being a party member in any given year, and over 40% reported not being a party member at all during this period.

Members and donors are essential to contemporary political parties, but in different ways. Members are a critical resource in intra-party leadership and nomination contests, while donors provide funds that sustain the extra-parliamentary party organization between elections and are the foundation for election spending. There is a rich cross-national literature that examines motivations to membership (i.e., Clark and Wilson 1961; Cross and Young 2008; Heidar and Kosiara-Pedersen 2019; Seyd and Whiteley 1992; Young and Cross 2002). While these studies may be suggestive, they cannot be assumed to apply to donors.

The Challenge of Studying Canadian Donors

Although there is an extensive literature that examines the motivations, attitudes, and behavior of other key groups in Canadian politics, such as voters, political aspirants, candidates, and party members (Blais and Daust 2020; Cross and Young 2011; Pruyzers and Blais 2019; Young and Cross 2002), there is relatively little research that examines donors. In other words, we know very little about who they are, what motivates them to give, and how they interact with Canadian party organizations. There are significant methodological challenges that stand in the way of surveying donors. Although political parties and candidates must disclose the names of their donors, use of those lists for any purpose is prohibited, so researchers cannot use them to identify the target population. Large n surveys of the public can ask respondents if they have made political contributions, and draw some conclusions based on the differences between those individuals and others who did not report making a contribution. There is a clear tendency for this methodology to identify a surprising large number of donors; for instance, McMahon et al. (2021) asked respondents on a survey of the Canadian general public whether they had made a political donation in the past year. They found that 18.6% of respondents reported having done so. If 19% of Canadians contributed to parties or candidates, we would be able to identify some 5.5 million donors annually (at both the federal and provincial

levels). This vastly exceeds the estimate of less than 1 million donors at the federal level over a four-year period (Rocha 2019). Tolley, Besco, and Sevi (2020, 4) note the same phenomenon of over-reporting, calculating that at most 2.6% of the population donates in any given year. The same problem of overreporting is well-established in the turnout literature, where reported rates of participation among survey respondents often exceed actual turnout by a significant margin (McGregor et al. 2020; Burden 2000; Karp and Brockington 2005).

Because of these research limitations, most analysis of donors to Canadian political parties has focused on which Canadians make political donations. Using the disclosed postal code of donors paired with census data, Carmichael and Howe (2014) find that donors are more likely to live in wealthier neighborhoods. More recently, a pair of articles have analyzed Elections Canada's administrative dataset, (which discloses the names of donors, the amounts they donated, and to whom) using predictive analytics to identify donor ethnicity (Besco and Tolley 2020) and gender (Tolley, Besco, and Sevi 2020). Besco and Tolley (2020) find that ethnic minorities donate at a lower rate than non-racialized Canadians, with the exception of South Asians who donate at "astonishingly high rates." Tolley, Besco, and Sevi (2020) report that women donate less often and in smaller amounts than men. Both studies identify affinity effects, in which members of minority groups are more likely to donate to candidates who share their ethnic identity and women are more likely to donate to female candidates. Beyond the insight these studies offer into the question of who donates, they point to a more general observation about donations in the Canadian context: there is a meaningful local element to it and personalized connections to the candidate motivate some donors. This is consistent with a general trend toward a personalization of electoral politics in Canada and elsewhere (Cross, Katz, and Pruyers 2018; Cross and Young 2015; Pruyers and Cross 2016; Zittel and Gschwend 2008).

To address the challenges of studying donors, we identified individuals who had reported on the Canada Elections Survey Study (CES) that they were donors. Respondents who indicated that they had made a donation were then invited to participate in a follow-up survey designed to better understand donors, including their motivation and patterns of contributions. Importantly, our first questions required respondents to provide detailed information about their donation history—amounts given and to which entities in the party. Because of the detail required of respondents, we are confident that they are, in fact, donors. While this yields a novel dataset, the number of respondents is a modest 256. Consequently, although this is perhaps the first survey of donors to Canadian political parties, offering original insight into motivations of these important actors within the Canadian political system, we consider this an exploratory investigation that warrants further replication given the limited sample.

Conceptions of Donors and Their Motivations

While it is helpful to understand *who* donates to Canadian parties and candidates, it is equally, if not more, important to understand *why* they donate. Conversations about regulation of political finance are grounded in normative assumptions about donor motivation. Accounts of the role and significance of donors within party organizations are couched in similar assumptions.

Through four decades of reforms to party and election finance legislation, one area of consistency and consensus has been a belief that relatively small contributions from individuals are a desirable source of money for political actors. As Parliament banned contributions from corporations and unions in 2003, imposed limits on the size of contributions from individuals in 2003 and again in 2006, and ended per-vote subsidies in 2011, small contributions from individuals remained a legitimate and even desirable source of money (for an account of these changes, see Young and Jansen 2011). The introduction and subsequent maintenance of the Political Finance Tax Credit in the 1970s, which subsidizes small contributions from individuals through a generous tax credit, supports and encourages these contributions.

Most analyses of individual donor motivation focus on the United States, a system which has relied on individual donations (often channeled through Political Action Committees) since the 1970s. Understanding donor behavior and motivations has been an important research question in the American literature (Barber 2016; Gimpel, Lee, and Kaminski 2006; Johnson 2010, 2013; Magleby et al. 2018). The categories of motivation for making political donations have often followed the same framework as motives for other political activities like party membership, and generally fall into the categories of purposive, material, and solidary incentives (Heerwig 2018; Seyd and Whiteley 1992; Young and Cross 2002).

Purposive incentives describe a desire to effect political, party, or ideological change. Many analyses of US donor motivations find that purposive incentives are the strongest predictor of donor behavior. Barber (2016) compares the behavior of PACs to the behavior of individual donors, and finds that individuals are motivated by ideology, and that donors whose views are more extreme (either left or right) give larger amounts than those who locate themselves at the center of the ideological spectrum. Magleby et al. (2014) conclude that issue agreement with the candidate is the strongest motivator of contributions, and LaRaja and Wiltse (2012) and Francia et al. (2003) find that ideological motivation predicts frequency of donation. Literature from the United States also suggests that political donors are more ideologically extreme than are party supporters generally, and that this is particularly true among those on the political right (see Bafumi and Herron 2010).

Material incentives to donate relate to personal gain, which might include access to a decision-maker, policy influence that affects a donor's business interests, or career advancement (such as through a government appointment). Many of the regulations governing political contributions assume that donors are motivated in this way. As Ansolabehere, de Figueiredo, and Snyder (2003) argue, much of the regulation of political donations assumes that donations are investments intended to yield benefit in the form of achieving a policy outcome or personal gain. They conclude, however, that there is little empirical evidence to support this conceptualization, as "individuals give because they are ideologically motivated, because they are excited by the politics of particular elections, because they are asked by their friends or colleagues and because they have the resources necessary to engage in this particular form of participation" (p. 117–8). In comparison with the United States, the relatively low limit on individual contributions in Canada might dampen expectations of significant personal rewards from the parties as no single contribution comprises a significant portion of a party or candidate's income.

Nonetheless, there have been recent news reports of parties checking names of potential judicial appointees against their donor lists (Platt 2020; Leblanc and Cardoso 2019).

Finally, solidary incentives refer to the social benefits that a donor might seek. These could include the opportunity to attend a fund-raising event, to spend time with fellow partisans, or to take in like-minded political content. While this is an important motivation for some in making the decision to join a political party (Young and Cross 2002), there is little evidence pointing to solidary incentives for political donations in the US literature. This likely speaks to the fact that most donations are (relatively) small checkbook donations as opposed to donations attached to specific fundraising dinners and events where donors can enjoy a range of social/solidary benefits. In this sense, checkbook donating is somewhat atomized and individualized.

When applying the US literature to Canada, it is important to take context into account. The organization of Canadian political parties has sometimes been described as “stratarchical,” with local and national organizations working together, often in a mutually dependent manner, to complete their various functions (Carty 2002; Cross 2018; Pruyers and Cross 2016). Fundraising is one such activity where the local and central party organizations are both actively engaged. The national party engages in e-mail and other digital fundraising efforts (often through the party’s central website), including prospecting demographically “likely” donors. Local party associations and candidates, by contrast, engage in a range of other fundraising activities, with an emphasis on in-person events and personalized connections.

Research Questions

Given the sparse literature regarding donor behavior and motivations in Canada, we adopt an exploratory approach in this article. While we are guided by the literature—based on Canadian party politics scholarship and American donor research—we put forth a series of exploratory research questions as opposed to explicit hypotheses.

- (1) **What motivates people to donate to political parties and/or candidates?** Building on research regarding the motivation to join parties (i.e., Seyd and Whiteley 1992; Young and Cross 2002), we consider whether donor motivations are driven by material, purposive, and solidary incentives.
- (2) **What individual differences—age, sex, income, party involvement—are related to different motivations to donate?** Are women and men motivated by different reasons to contribute? Do motivations vary by party? Do individuals more heavily engaged in party activity identify different patterns of motivation for giving?
- (3) **How does motivation affect specific donating behavior?** In particular, we consider whether motivations can help us understand how donors interact with Canada’s stratarchically organized political parties. Donors have the opportunity to give locally (EDA or candidate) and/or nationally (to the central party). Thus, the question for us is whether motivations are related to giving at the grassroots versus national level. This in turn helps us to understand the role of donors within the ecosystem of contemporary Canadian political parties.

Data and Measures

Our survey of political donors was conducted using the online survey platform Qualtrics during two and a half weeks in November 2020 (November 12–30). The final dataset includes 256 valid responses. Respondents were drawn from a larger pool of donors who were identified from the 2019 Canadian Election Study (CES) (Stephenson et al. 2020). To identify donors, we included the following screening question in the 2019 CES:

Since the 2015 federal election, have you donated money to any federal political party or candidate, beyond buying a party membership? (This includes any national party, a local federal party association, a candidate in a federal election, someone running to be a candidate in a federal election, or a candidate for the leadership of a federal party).

Of the 37,822 individuals who participated in the 2019 CES, nine percent (or 3,450 individuals) reported that they had donated to a federal political party during this period. In cooperation with Qualtrics, the firm responsible for administering the 2019 CES, we re-contacted these donors to administer an original survey of party donors. To ensure our respondents were indeed donors, the same screening question that was included in the 2019 CES was also included in our follow up survey. Responding “no,” indicating that the respondent had not donated, terminating their participation in the survey.

The profile of the 256 donors in our dataset is consistent with what we would expect given the characteristics of party members more broadly (Cross and Young 2004; Cross 2019). The age of respondents ranges between 20 and 84, with a mean of 54.5 (SD = 15.86). A clear majority of respondents are men (67%), while 32% are women, and less than one percent self-identify as non-binary or opted not to answer. More than three-in-four respondents report being born in Canada (78.4%) and 98% are Canadian citizens. The majority have a university education (72.2%) and half (49.8%) report being employed full time.

While our questions are not entirely comparable to what was asked of the larger pool of donors identified in the CES, we can compare our subset on several measures (see Appendix B). Such a comparison reveals that our data are largely reflective of this larger pool of donors on characteristics such as age, employment status, the percentage born in Canada, etc. Another way of considering the representativeness of our sample is to compare it to recent work that draws upon analysis of the actual lists of donors based on Elections Canada financial reports. Here too our sample is reflective. We find that women comprise 32% of our respondents. Tolley, Besco, and Sevi (2020) find that (recently) women are between 34% (2018) and 38% (2016) of donors. Likewise, we find that three in four donors are born in Canada. This is consistent with Besco and Tolley’s (2020) estimate that 81% of donations come from individuals with European backgrounds. Overall, then, we have good reason to be confident in our sample of donors.

To answer our first research question (why do people donate?), we draw upon a battery of eleven questions designed to capture motivations for donating. For each item, participants were asked to identify the importance of each potential motivation on a three-point Likert scale (not at all/somewhat/very important). The battery included the following items: I was asked by a friend; I know the person running for office; I think it’s really important to have a good person represent my community in Ottawa; I wanted to attend the event—I had to make a donation to get a ticket; It’s important to my career success;

I need to be seen at party fundraising events; I want to have time with politicians, face to face; I believe the party leader would be a good Prime Minister; I support the party's values and policies; I want to help my party keep another party out of office; and I think it's my obligation as a citizen. As described in further detail in the results section, factor analysis reveals two underlying motivational factors that we then analyze further. To answer our second question, we explore the correlates of each of these two motivational factors, focusing on common individual characteristics such as age, sex, income, and party affiliation. We also include a scale of party activism, made from six possible party activities that the respondent could be engaged with (attended a regular meeting of the local party association, served on your local party association's executive, attended a national party convention, attended a social event organized by your party, engaged in fundraising activities for your party, encouraged others to join the party). These activities are then combined and summed to a 0–6 scale.

Finally, to answer our third question, we explore the relationship between donor motivation and patterns of giving. We do so in three ways. First, we consider whether the donation is made locally or nationally by examining the reported donation patterns of respondents. Party and leadership contestants are considered national whereas EDAs and candidates are considered local. Second, we ask respondents how they would donate \$100, splitting it any way they like between the national and local levels. We ask respondents to consider this hypothetical contribution inside and outside of an election period. Finally, we consider the total amount that respondents report donating in 2019.

Results

Why Do People Donate?

The first question this article seeks to address is what motivates individuals to contribute to political parties, campaigns, and candidates in Canada. [Figure 2](#) presents the summary of responses provided to the 11 prompts. The most common prompts that respondents deemed “very important” were related to partisan politics, including supporting the party's values and policies, having a good prime minister, sending a good representative to Ottawa, and keeping another party out of office. Less common were strong responses to prompts such as being seen at or attending events or being asked by a friend. In addition to these more specific motivations, our data reveal that a considerable minority of donors are self-motivated. Indeed, nearly four-in-ten donors (37%) report that they take the initiative to donate without being asked to do so ([Figure 3](#)).

This matches with responses to the question of what motivated the respondent to make their first donation ([Figure 4](#)). We find once again that the strongest motivator (at 40%) was “strongly supporting the party at the time”—an indicator of political motivation. More transactional motivations, like attending an event or knowing someone running as a candidate, were less frequently identified.

To further explore motivations, we conducted a factor analysis on the battery of 11 motivation questions. The results identified two underlying dimensions with eigen values greater than one that accounted for a combined 58% of the total variance. As [Table 1](#) demonstrates, we find a relatively clear division between two types of motivations: what we call transactional motivations and political motivations.

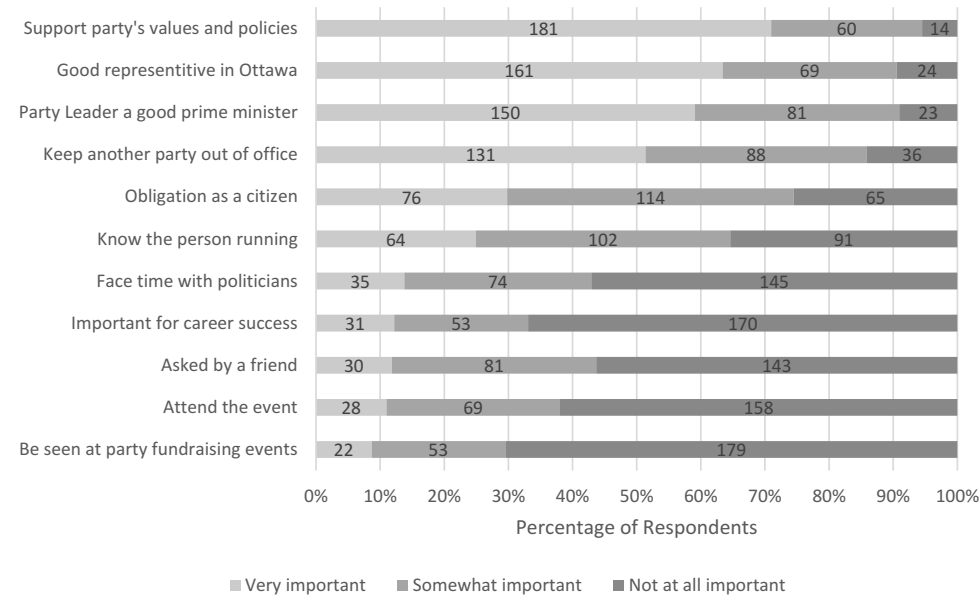


Figure 2. Responses to motivation questions. Note: Raw total of responses reported in the bar, with percentage depicted on the x axis. Not all respondents answered each question, thus the N varies slightly between motivation.

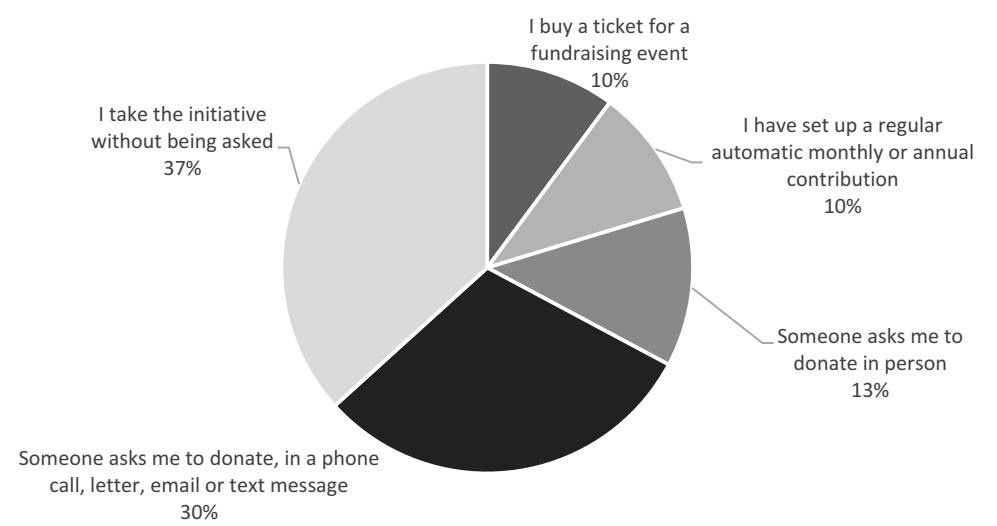


Figure 3. Which of the following best describes the way that you usually end up making a contribution to a candidate or a party? Note: Respondents could select one option only. Missing responses not included in this chart.

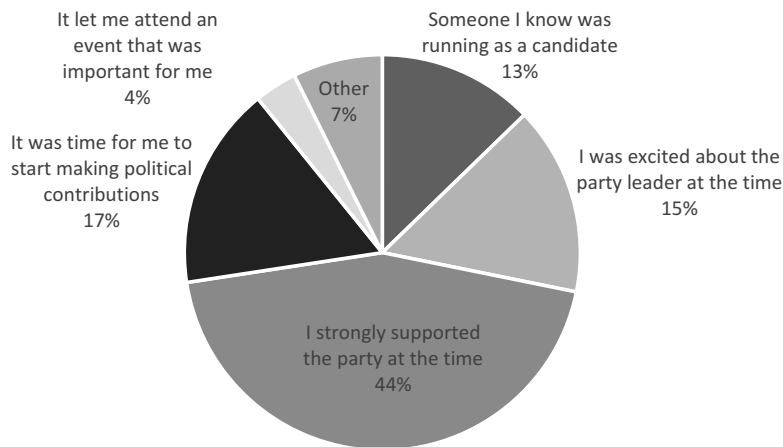


Figure 4. What made you decide to give that first donation? Note: Respondents could select one option only. Missing responses not included in this chart.

Table 1. Factor analysis (motivations for donating).

Item	Factor 1 (Transactional)	Factor 2 (Political)
I was asked by a friend	0.7308	−0.0157
I know the person running for office	0.6092	0.1719
I think it’s really important to have a good person represent my community in Ottawa	−0.0685	0.577
I wanted to attend the event; I had to make a donation to get a ticket	0.8374	−0.1224
It’s important to my career success	0.8499	−0.002
I need to be seen at party fundraising events	0.884	−0.0394
I want to have time with politicians, face to face	0.7778	0.0754
I believe the party leader would be a good Prime Minister	0.0231	0.8017
I support the party’s values and policies	−0.1526	0.8083
I want to help my party keep another party out of office	0.0298	0.7305
I think it’s my obligation as a citizen	0.3535	0.5098

Note: Principal-component factor method, varimax rotated factors.

The first factor identified in [Table 1](#) captures motivations related to interpersonal or network connections. We identify these as **transactional motivations**. In terms of individual items, this includes being asked by a friend or knowing the person running for office, or wanting to be seen by others or to get facetime with the politicians themselves. In these cases, donating is related to maintaining and growing one’s network (i.e., attending events) or personal objectives (i.e., career advancement). This collection of motivations encompasses both material incentives (need to be seen/career success) and solidary incentives (desire to attend an event or support a friend). In other words, they are somewhat transactional in nature. However, as [Figure 2](#) suggests, these transactional motivations were less commonly stated as very important to the respondent. The second factor, on the other hand, rests more on **political motivations**—to influence who is representing their community as a member of parliament, which party’s leader would be best suited as prime minister, to support the party’s values or policies, or to directly prevent another party from winning office. These correspond to what is referred to as “purposive” incentives above. In this case, donating is a means to achieve a political

objective as opposed to more personal objectives.³ These responses were more commonly “very important” to the respondents. Interestingly, our analysis does not replicate the tripartite model of material, solidary, and purposive incentives/motivations that have been documented elsewhere. In fact, what we call “transactional” motivation includes both solidary (i.e., personal connection) and material (i.e., career success) elements. This highlights a potential divergence between the incentives/motivations of members and donors.

From this factor analysis, we were able to create two sets of variables that represent the strength of both factors for each individual donor surveyed. The first is a factor variable, centered on 0, and the second is a variable that provides a mean of the 1–3 scores of each of the variables included in each factor. Analyses with each of these variables produced a similar pattern of results. As such, and in order to simplify the results, we make use of the variables calculated using item means. In the overall dataset, we see a higher mean for political motivations (at a mean of 2.24), compared with transactional motivations (at a mean of 1.39). It is important to note that this does not mean that any individual donor is only an transactional or political donor. A donor could easily score high on both political and transactional motivations. Instead, this reflects the strength of that particular factor in their individual motivations. There is a positive correlation between the mean scores of the political and transactional motivations (0.56, $p < 0.001$), suggesting that respondents with high scores on one factor will more likely be higher on the second factor as well.

The Correlates of Donor Motivations

Using the mean scores derived from the factors identified in Table 1 as our dependent variable, we can model some of the socio-demographic and attitudinal variables that may be correlated with whether an individual donor scores higher or lower for each of these motivations to donate (Table 2). Here we consider variables such as age, sex, income, party identification, and party activism. In other words, now that we have a sense of why individuals donate (Table 1), the goal here is to better understand *who* tends to be motivated most by political and transactional objectives. Bivariate correlations are reported in text due to the small sample size.⁴

We find that as **age** increases, the strength of a donor’s transactional motivation tends to decrease ($-0.47, p < 0.01$). The opposite is true for political motivations, which increase with age ($0.32, p < 0.01$). Given their stage in the life cycle, younger donors should be more concerned with career-building and the associated professional networking that can be attached with donating politically, especially when it involves a fundraiser or event. This is

Table 2. Correlations of motivations and behaviors.

	Transactional (Mean Variable)	Political (Mean Variable)
Total Value of Donations	0.20***	0.15**
Percent to National	-0.27***	0.05
Percent to Local	0.28***	-0.06
Hypothetical \$100—% to National Party	-0.21***	0.04
Hypothetical \$100—% to National Party (Election Year)	-0.18***	0.05
Hypothetical \$100 -% to Local Party	0.21***	-0.04
Hypothetical \$100 -% to Local Party (Election Year)	0.20***	-0.05

Note: * $p < 0.10$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$.

especially true given that the pool of donors skews toward older voters and thus includes many retired individuals who are likely to be less interested in the potential career benefits of their donations, but may have strong views about which party should form government.

Regarding **gender**, we find some indication of women being more motivated by political considerations than men. However, once other factors are considered in the regression analysis ([Appendix A](#)), being a woman predicts a higher score on transactional motivation and the gender difference on political motivation disappears. Looking at the specific questions on motivation, we find a statistically significant gender difference on many items associated with transactional motivation. Women are more likely to say that being asked by a friend to donate was important ($p < .05$), that they needed to be seen at fundraising events ($p < .1$), and that they wanted to have time face-to-face with politicians at events ($p < .1$). We suspect that women may be motivated by transactional factors for a number of reasons. First, as a historically marginalized group, women may view financial contributions as a means of challenging their outsider status within party politics and therefore access some potential benefits that partisan politics has to offer. Men, by contrast, are more likely to be party insiders—members, EDA members, candidates, etc.—and therefore have access to partisan spoils in other ways. Second, the personalized nature of this type of motivation (asked by a friend, knew the candidate, etc.) may also be consistent with the recent findings of Tolley, Besco, and Sevi (2020) regarding gender affinity and political donations.

Previous research has noted that donation amounts (and donating at all) is related to **income** (Ansolabehere, de Figueiredo, and Snyder 2003; Francia 2003; Gimpel, Lee, and Kaminski 2006; Jacobson, 1980; James 2009; Jones 1990; Lipsitz & Panagopoulos 2011; Schlozman et al. 2012; Verba et al. 1995). We see little difference in transactional motivations for donating by income levels ([Figure 5](#)). However, we do find that political motivation does somewhat decrease as income levels increase.

Turning to **political party affiliation** ([Figure 6](#)), we note that transactional motivations are highest for the Bloc Quebecois, Liberal, and Conservative Parties. This finding makes

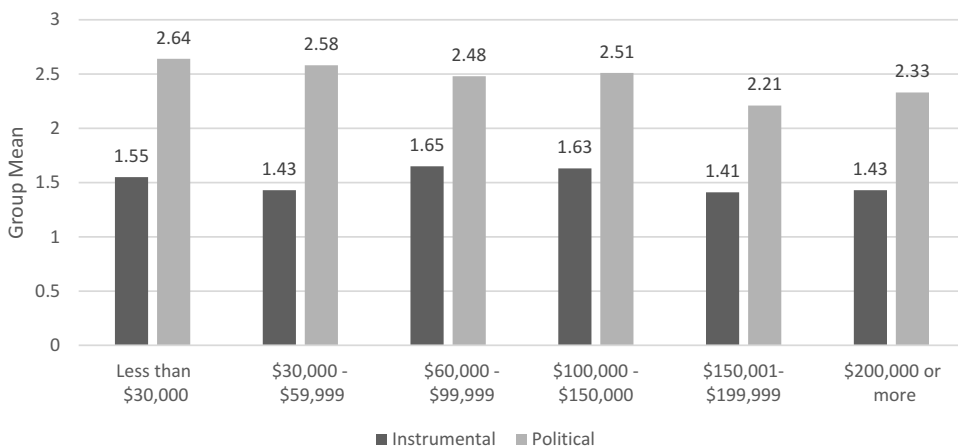


Figure 5. Income categories and motivations, group means. Note: Transactional: One-Way ANOVA, $p > 0.1$; Political: One-Way ANOVA, $p < 0.01$.

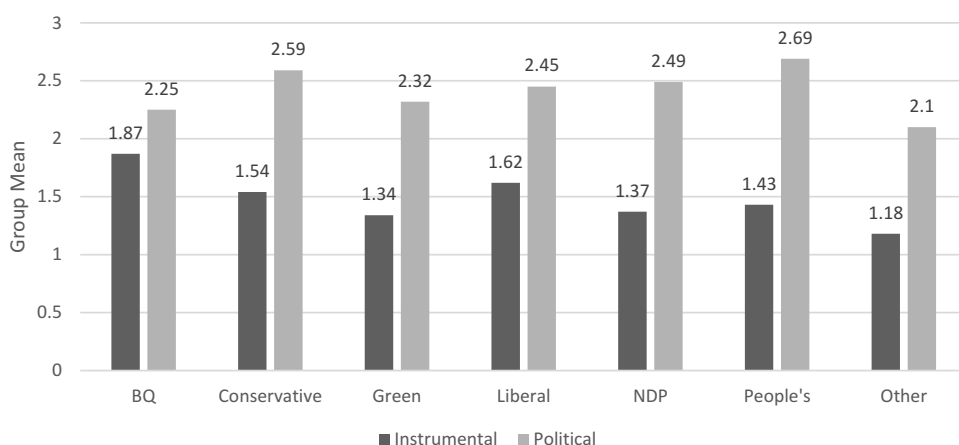


Figure 6. Political parties and motivations, group means. Note: Transactional: One-Way ANOVA, $p < 0.1$; Political: One-Way ANOVA, $p < 0.1$

sense when you consider the types of responses that would strengthen one's transactional motivation: to be seen at an event, get facetime with a politician, or advancing one's career. This may not be so motivating when the event or politicians in question are from a smaller party or one unlikely to form government. Political motivations are highest on the right end of the ideological spectrum, with the People's Party and Conservative Party supporters with the highest group means.

Finally, we consider a measure of the voter's **activism or engagement with party politics**. Unsurprisingly, we see that those involved in more types of party activities will also be more transactionally motivated to donate ($0.52 p < 0.01$). Transactional motivations for donations are often similar to the motivations to join and be active in political parties, which draw heavily on personalized recruitment networks (Pruysers and Cross 2016). Comparing those donors who are party members to those who are not, we find no differences in political motivations: both are motivated to see their preferred party do well. But those respondents who were members of a party are more likely to say that it was important to them to be seen at a party fundraiser, that donating was important to their career, or that donating allowed them to attend an event.⁵

Do Motivations Affect Specific Donating Behavior?

The third question we address is whether motivations can predict specific donating behaviors. Here the two motivation variables identified in the factor analysis are treated as independent variables to predict specific behaviors.

The first dependent variable considers total donations, in dollars. Higher motivation scores—either political or transactional—are positively correlated with a higher dollar value of donations. We also consider whether motivations can predict the percentage of donations that are given to the national versus local party. For this, self-reported donations were classified as national (to the party or to leadership) or local (local candidate, nomination campaign, or EDA). Then, the percentage of the total donations to each of these sources was calculated. Another way to gauge how this impacts behavior is to

consider the responses of donors when asked how they would split up their donations if given \$100 to give away, with response options of national party or local party. Participants were asked to respond twice to the hypothetical, once as if it was a non-election year and once for an election year (See [Table 2](#)).

Higher transactional motivation scores are positively correlated with percentage of donations to the local party or campaign, and negatively correlated with percentage of donations to the national campaign. This finding is intuitive, as the motivations that made up the transactional scale center more on events, activities, and candidates that happen at that local level. For example, if a transactional donor is motivated by their desire to be seen at a party event to benefit their career, they would be more likely to donate at the local level, the level at which this event would likely be held. Similarly, if they were motivated by a candidate asking them to donate to their campaign, they would be supporting that individual candidate at the local level. The analysis, by contrast, indicates that *political motivations* are not a strong predictor, either way, of where the donor is giving their donation (whether national or local). In other words, those who are motivated by political considerations (policy, representation, and ideology) do not give primarily to one level compared to another. On the one hand, this may seem counterintuitive. After all, the literature on presidentialization and personalization of politics (Poguntke and Webb 2005; Bittner 2011), which emphasizes a growing importance of party leaders, would suggest that donors with political motivations would be drawn to the national level. The fact that this is not borne out by the data, however, likely speaks to the multi-level nature of Canadian parties and the campaigns that they run (Carty 2004). The stratarchical organizational structure of Canadian parties combined with the single member plurality electoral system that highlights local campaigns means that donors can be, and indeed are, active at multiple levels.

Conclusions

Drawing on an original survey, this article has explored a vital, yet understudied, set of actors in Canadian political life: donors to political parties. Probing donors' motivations, we find two dimensions of motivation to contribute financially. We distinguish between *political motivations* (i.e., a desire to elect their preferred party or to prevent other parties from winning) and *transactional motivations* (i.e., a desire to further one's own career or make or solidify personal connections). Interestingly, our analysis does not replicate the tripartite model of material, solidary, and purposive incentives/motivations that have been documented elsewhere. In fact, our factor analysis reveals that transactional motivation includes both solidary (i.e., personal connection) and material (i.e., career success) elements. This highlights an important potential divergence between the incentives/motivations of members and donors that should be the subject of future research.

In the subsequent analysis, we find that donors are more likely to report stronger political motivations than transactional ones. In general, donors expressing high political motivations tended to be older and less wealthy, but we also note that the strength of the political motivation does not relate to specific donor behaviors.

Nonetheless, a smaller group also reported being motivated by transactional reasons: they wanted face time with politicians, they needed to be seen at fundraising events, they thought it would help their career, or they simply wanted to attend an event. Younger

donors, supporters of the major parties, women, and party members are more likely to express these transactional motivations. These transactional donors were also distinctive in their behavior, being more likely to give locally (whether to the EDA or to a candidate) and giving smaller amounts, on average. This speaks to the stratarchical character of Canadian political parties. The national party engages virtually with donors, appealing to their desire to see the party compete successfully in elections. Local party organizations engage with donors who share this desire for the party's success, but who are also connected into the local political community. For these transactional donors, the value of a brief chat with a politician, the ability to be seen to be a party supporter, and interpersonal connections to candidates and others are important.

To the extent that donors, like party members, are means by which national political parties are connected to civil society, the virtual ties of politically motivated donors are arguably less robust and meaningful than the interactive connections of transactional donors who engage more directly with the party organization on the ground. Politically motivated donors seek to amplify their partisan support through financial contributions. Transactional voters seek to further their own interests, and those of their social networks, through local engagement.

As is generally the case, the results presented here raise several new questions. We end, therefore, with some brief suggestions for future research. First, on the question of motivation, future research would benefit from a more fulsome consideration of whether donors are motivated internally or externally and how differences in self-motivation impact donation patterns. Second, and relatedly, future research may consider the effectiveness of party appeals for donations. In other words, what types of messages (and platforms) are the most effective at mobilizing financial contributions? Third, and finally, the collection of longitudinal data would allow researchers to consider questions such as how an individual donor first began to donate, and whether, like voting, donation as a form of political participation is habit-forming. Regardless of the precise avenue, more research on this understudied subset of party supporters is warranted.

Notes

1. Donors can give up to a set amount to each of the following: to each registered party; in total to all the registered associations, nomination contestants, and candidates of each registered party; in total to all leadership contestants in a particular contest; and to each independent candidate. In 2022, the limit was \$1675 to each of the groups above. This total is indexed to inflation, so it rises annually.
2. This is part of a large trend of multi-speed membership strategies (Scarrow 2015).
3. Note that "Obligation as a citizen" was ultimately not included in either factor as it did not load on to either factor neatly.
4. [Appendix A](#) provides full regression models as available, which take into consideration the potential covariates together. In the text, the results for the mean variables (rather than factor variables) are reported for ease of interpretation. A full set of results is available in [Appendix B](#).
5. All statistically significant at $p < .05$.

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Notes on contributors

Holly Ann Garnett is an Associate Professor of Political Science at the Royal Military College of Canada and cross-appointed at Queen's University. She is co-director of the Electoral Integrity Project and studies issues relating to the quality of elections in Canada and around the globe, including electoral management bodies, registration and voting, cyber-security, and election technology, civic literacy, and campaign finance.

Scott Pruyzers is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Political Science at Dalhousie University. His research focuses on questions of participation and representation in party and electoral politics. His writing has including topics such as political ambition, nomination and recruitment, and leadership selection and removal.

Lisa Young is a Professor of Political Science at the University of Calgary. Her current research focuses on election finance, Alberta politics, and graduate education.

William P. Cross is Professor of Political Science at Carleton University in Ottawa, Canada. His research is focussed on questions relating to political party organization and intraparty democracy. He has published extensively on party members, party leadership selection, and candidate nomination.

ORCID

Holly Ann Garnett  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-2119-4399>

Scott Pruyzers  <http://orcid.org/0000-0001-5557-0404>

Lisa Young  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-2654-3874>

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Appendix A: Regression Analysis

Table A1: What predicts the Strength of Each Motivation?

	(1) Transactional (Mean 1-3 score)	(2) Political (Mean 1-3 score)
Age (linear)	-0.01***	0.01***
	0.00	0.00
Female	0.13**	0.04
	0.06	0.07
\$30,000 - \$59,999	-0.09	-0.10
	0.11	0.12
\$60,000 - \$99,999	-0.03	-0.16
	0.11	0.12
\$100,000 - \$150,000	-0.03	-0.11
	0.11	0.12
\$150,001 - \$199,999	-0.16	-0.35**
	0.12	0.14
\$200,000 or more	-0.21	-0.33**
	0.15	0.16
BQ	0.04	-0.10
	0.16	0.18
Conservative	-0.01	0.09
	0.07	0.07
Green	-0.31**	-0.10
	0.12	0.13
NDP	-0.18*	0.02
	0.09	0.10
People's	-0.16	0.18
	0.16	0.18
Other	-0.41***	-0.46***
	0.16	0.17
Party Activism Scale	0.12***	0.03*
	0.02	0.02
Constant	2.14***	1.98***
	0.16	0.17
N	240	240
R-sq	0.44	0.20

Standard errors in second row ** $p < 0.10$ *** $p < 0.05$ **** $p < 0.01$ HT

Reference category: Income – Below \$30 000, Party- Liberal Party

Table A2: Percentage of Donation Total to National vs. Local.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Percent to National	Percent to National	Percent to Local	Percent to Local
Age (linear)	0.00*	0.00	-0.00*	-0.00
	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Female	-0.01	0.01	0.01	-0.01
	0.06	0.06	0.06	0.06
\$30,000 - \$59,999	0.02	0.01	-0.01	0.01
	0.12	0.12	0.12	0.12
\$60,000 - \$99,999	-0.09	-0.10	0.11	0.12
	0.11	0.11	0.12	0.12
\$100,000 - \$150,000	-0.13	-0.13	0.14	0.14
	0.12	0.11	0.12	0.12
\$150,001- \$199,999	-0.03	-0.06	0.04	0.07
	0.13	0.13	0.13	0.13
\$200,000 or more	-0.03	-0.08	0.06	0.12
	0.15	0.15	0.16	0.16
BQ	0.06	0.06	-0.07	-0.06
	0.16	0.16	0.16	0.16
Conservative	0.02	0.02	-0.03	-0.03
	0.07	0.07	0.07	0.07
Green	-0.19	-0.25**	0.26*	0.31**
	0.12	0.12	0.14	0.13
NDP	-0.07	-0.09	0.06	0.08
	0.10	0.10	0.10	0.10
People's	-0.02	-0.04	0.02	0.03
	0.16	0.16	0.16	0.16
Other	-0.07	-0.12	0.07	0.12
	0.16	0.16	0.16	0.16
Party Activism	-0.04**	-0.02	0.04**	0.02
	0.02	0.02	0.02	0.02
Political Motivation	0.02		-0.02	
	0.06		0.06	
Transactional Motivation		-0.15**		0.15**
		0.07		0.07
Constant	0.49**	0.86***	0.49**	0.11
	0.21	0.22	0.21	0.22
N	207	207	202	202
R-sq	0.11	0.14	0.12	0.14

Standard errors in second row ** $p < 0.10$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$ HT

Reference category: Income – Below \$30 000, Party- Liberal Party Motivation variables included in separate models as to reduce changes of multicollinearity.

Table A3: If you had 100 to give away, where would you direct it?

	(1) National Party	(2) National Party	(3) Local Association	(4) Local Association	(5) National Party (Election Year)	(6) National Party (Election Year)	(7) Local Association (Election Year)	(8) Local Association (Election Year)
Age (linear)	0.19	0.00	-0.19	-0.00	0.09	-0.05	-0.23	-0.09
	0.18	0.19	0.18	0.19	0.18	0.19	0.18	0.18
Female	1.50	3.10	-1.50	-3.10	-1.07	0.71	-2.37	-3.96
	5.63	5.59	5.63	5.59	5.67	5.67	5.57	5.58
\$30,000 - \$59,999	7.86	6.38	-7.86	-6.38	0.51	-0.59	-7.93	-6.99
	9.70	9.59	9.70	9.59	9.85	9.75	9.68	9.60
\$60,000 -\$99,999	9.09	8.69	-9.09	-8.69	3.04	2.71	-10.28	-10.08
	9.20	9.05	9.20	9.05	9.32	9.20	9.16	9.05
\$100,000 - \$150,000	7.72	7.12	-7.72	-7.12	-1.06	-1.47	-8.41	-8.15
	9.65	9.50	9.65	9.50	9.91	9.77	9.73	9.62
\$150,001- \$199,999	13.55	12.44	-13.55	-12.44	-1.05	-2.75	-11.91	-10.57
	10.88	10.69	10.88	10.69	11.02	10.85	10.83	10.68
\$200,000 or more	16.53	13.09	-16.53	-13.09	8.46	5.05	-17.13	-14.29
	12.83	12.66	12.83	12.66	13.06	12.91	12.83	12.71
BQ	5.49	8.55	-5.49	-8.55	-15.97	-16.09	-3.42	-3.35
	17.11	16.92	17.11	16.92	14.96	14.79	14.70	14.56
Conservative	4.28	4.15	-4.28	-4.15	2.46	2.26	-3.83	-3.62
	6.02	5.93	6.02	5.93	6.11	6.04	6.00	5.94
Green	-9.16	-13.72	9.16	13.72	-3.80	-8.42	8.37	12.34
	10.84	10.81	10.84	10.81	11.02	11.04	10.83	10.87
NDP	-14.34*	-17.04**	14.34*	17.04**	-11.10	-13.27	10.55	12.49
	8.45	8.41	8.45	8.41	8.63	8.60	8.48	8.46
People's	-1.55	-3.73	1.55	3.73	-14.33	-16.18	0.95	2.70
	13.88	13.71	13.88	13.71	14.13	13.98	13.88	13.76
Other	-26.77*	-30.19**	26.77*	30.19**	-28.33**	-31.99**	25.67*	28.72**
	14.05	13.86	14.05	13.86	14.31	14.16	14.05	13.94
Party Activism	-3.61**	-1.69	3.61**	1.69	-2.15	-0.49	3.45**	1.98
	1.53	1.71	1.53	1.71	1.55	1.71	1.52	1.68
Political Motivation	-1.00		1.00		0.87		0.06	
	5.83		5.83		5.85		5.75	
Transactional Motivation		-14.37**		14.37**		-13.05**		11.65*
		6.07		6.07		6.07		5.97
Constant	53.00***	81.27***	47.00**	18.73	60.93***	89.91***	52.36***	28.27
	18.59	18.73	18.59	18.73	18.76	18.82	18.43	18.52
N	215	215	215	215	218	218	218	218
R-sq	0.10	0.12	0.10	0.12	0.06	0.08	0.09	0.11

Standard errors in second row *** $p < 0.10$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$ HT

Reference category: Income – Below \$30 000, Party- Liberal Party Motivation variables included in separate models as to reduce changes of multicollinearity

Table A4: Motivation to Donate and Amount Contributed.

	(1) Total Donations 2019	(2) Total Donations 2019
Age (linear)	0.19	0.00
	0.18	0.19
Female	1.50	3.10
	5.63	5.59
\$30,000 - \$59,999	7.86	6.38
	9.70	9.59
\$60,000 - \$99,999	9.09	8.69
	9.20	9.05
\$100,000 - \$150,000	7.72	7.12
	9.65	9.50
\$150,001- \$199,999	13.55	12.44
	10.88	10.69
\$200,000 or more	16.53	13.09
	12.83	12.66
BQ	5.49	8.55
	17.11	16.92
Conservative	4.28	4.15
	6.02	5.93
Green	-9.16	-13.72
	10.84	10.81
NDP	-14.34*	-17.04**
	8.45	8.41
People's	-1.55	-3.73
	13.88	13.71
Other	-26.77*	-30.19**
	14.05	13.86
Activism	-3.61**	-1.69
	1.53	1.71
Political Motivation	-1.00	
	5.83	
Transactional Motivation		-14.37**
		6.07
Constant	53.00***	81.27***
	18.59	18.73
N	215	215
R-sq	0.10	0.12

Standard errors in second row ** $p < 0.10$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$ HT

Reference category: Income – Below \$30 000, Party- Liberal Party Motivation variables included in separate models as to reduce changes of multicollinearity

Appendix B: Bivariate Analysis

Table B1: Donation Motivations.

	Mean Variable – Transactional	Factor Variable – Transactional	Mean Variable – Political	Factor Variable – Political
Age (scale)	Corr -0.47	Corr -0.46	Corr 0.32	Corr 0.36
Gender Categories	One-way ANOVA Male 1.48 Female 1.66	One-way ANOVA Male -0.08 Female 0.18	One-way ANOVA Male 2.47 Female 2.53 ***	One-way ANOVA Male 0.02 Female0.02*
Income Categories	One-way ANOVA A Less than \$30 000 B 1.43 C1.65 D1.63 E1.41 F1.43	One-way ANOVA A 0.18 B-0.27 C0.22 D 0.17 E-0.13 F-0.19	One-way ANOVA A 2.64 B 2.58 C2.48 D2.51 E2.21 F2.33 ***	One-way ANOVA A 0.36 B0.12 C0.46 D-0.03 E-0.39 F-0.36 **
Party Categories	One-way ANOVA BQ 1.87 Con1.54 Green1.34 Liberal1.62 NDP1.37 Peoples1.43 Other1.18 *	One-way ANOVA BQ 0.49 Con 0.03 Green -0.38 Liberal 0.19 NDP-0.34 Peoples -0.24 Other -0.48 **	One-way ANOVA BQ 2.25 Con 2.59 Green2.32 Liberal2.45 NDP2.49 Peoples2.69 Other2.1 *	One-way ANOVA BQ -0.55 Con 0.13 Green -0.25 Liberal 0.04 NDP-0.02 Peoples 0.21 Other -0.53
Party Activism (scale)	Corr 0.52***	Corr 0.51***	Corr 0.19***	Corr -0.02

* $p<0.10$ ** $p<0.05$ *** $p<0.01$

Table B2: Correlations with Donation Behavior.

	Factor Variable – Transactional	Mean Variable – Transactional	Factor Variable – Political	Mean Variable – Political
Total Donations	0.20***	0.20***	-0.05	0.15**
Percent to National	-0.27***	-0.27***	0.03	0.05
Percent to Local	0.28***	0.28***	-0.03	-0.06
\$100 - National Party	-0.19***	-0.21***	0.03	0.04
\$100 - National Party (Election Year)	-0.16**	-0.18***	0.04	0.05
\$100 - Local Party	0.17***	0.21***	-0.03	-0.04
\$100 - Local Party (Election Year)	0.18**	0.20***	-0.05	-0.05

* $p<0.10$ ** $p<0.05$ *** $p<0.01$

Appendix C.

Table C1: Canadian Election Study Donor Characteristics Compared with Donor Survey Characteristics.

	CES 2019 Survey (Donors)	Our Dataset
Age (mean)	49	54
Female (%)	43%	32%
Born in Canada (%)	78%	78%
Post-Secondary Education (completed college, university, technical training etc.) (%)	70%	78%
Full Time Employment (%)	45%	50%